Mei Zhou

四季食疗

Eat for the Season

A plain-English guide to Chinese food therapy



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With twenty-four soups and teas · First edition

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Before You Begin

My grandmother never read a book about Chinese medicine. She didn't know the names of the meridians, and if you had asked her about yin and yang she would have laughed. But she knew that you give a child with a chill ginger and brown sugar, that you eat mung beans when the summer is heavy, and that pears are for the dry weeks of autumn when everyone starts to cough. She knew it the way she knew which way the wind blew.

That kind of knowledge is what this book is about. In China it is called *shí liáo* 食疗, food therapy, or more simply *yǎng shēng* 养生, nourishing life. It is not a medical treatment. It is a set of habits, two thousand years old, for choosing food according to the season, the weather and the person who will eat it.

In my cookbook, *Mei's Chinese Home Kitchen*, every recipe carries a little red label that says *warm*, *cool* or *neutral*. This book explains what those labels mean, and much more. It explains, as plainly as I can, how Chinese families think about food: which foods warm and which cool, what the five flavors do, how to notice your own tendencies, and how to eat through the year. At the end of each season you will find soups and teas to make.

I have tried to keep it practical. You won't need to buy expensive herbs or visit special shops. Almost everything here can be found in a large supermarket, and the rest at any Asian grocery.

A word of honesty before we begin. Chinese food therapy grew from long observation, not from modern laboratory science, and its ideas are a way of thinking rather than a set of proven facts. I find them useful and wise, and I think you will too. But they are no substitute for a doctor, and nothing in these pages should make you stop a medicine or delay seeing someone when you are unwell.

Cook slowly, eat warmly, and pay attention to how you feel. That is most of it.

Mei

Chapter Two

寒凉平温热
Hot, Warm, Neutral, Cool, Cold

The five natures of food



Chinese cinnamon, Cinnamomum cassia. From Köhler's Medizinal-Pflanzen, Gera, 1887–1898.

its natural nature. Stir-frying warms it a little. Deep-frying, grilling, roasting and long baking warm it the most.

This is why a raw radish is cooling and good for a heavy stomach in summer, while radish simmered for an hour with beef becomes a gentle winter food. It is also why Chinese families cook most vegetables, even in summer.

Pairing to balance

Chinese dishes often combine a cool ingredient with a warm one so that the finished dish sits closer to neutral. Once you notice this, you will see it everywhere:

- Crab, which is cold, is eaten with ginger and warm vinegar.
- Cucumber, which is cool, is dressed with garlic.
- Lamb, which is hot, is stewed with cooling daikon radish.
- Tofu, which is cool, is cooked with scallion and ginger.
- Mung bean soup, which is cold, is eaten in summer, sometimes with a slice of ginger for those with a sensitive stomach.

The five natures of everyday foods

The table below shows the traditional nature of common foods. Different classical sources sometimes disagree by one step, and I have followed the most widely accepted modern references. Use it as a guide, not a rulebook.

Grains and beans

Food	Nature	Food	Nature
Rice	Neutral	Glutinous (sticky) rice	Warm
Millet	Cool	Oats	Warm
Wheat and flour	Cool	Corn	Neutral
Buckwheat	Cool	Barley and coix seed	Cool
Mung beans	Cold	Adzuki beans	Neutral
Soybeans and soy milk	Neutral	Black beans	Neutral

The Questionnaire

Group A	Score
I tire easily, or get out of breath with light effort.	0 · 1 · 2
I catch colds more easily than other people.	0 · 1 · 2
My voice is soft, and I often don't feel like talking.	0 · 1 · 2
I sweat easily, even when I am not exerting myself.	0 · 1 · 2
	Total: _____

Group B	Score
My hands and feet are cold, even indoors.	0 · 1 · 2
I feel the cold more than others and wear more layers.	0 · 1 · 2
Cold food or iced drinks upset my stomach.	0 · 1 · 2
I tend to have loose stools, or get up at night to urinate.	0 · 1 · 2
	Total: _____

Group C	Score
My palms and the soles of my feet feel hot.	0 · 1 · 2
My mouth, throat, eyes or skin feel dry.	0 · 1 · 2
I feel flushed or warm in the afternoon or at night.	0 · 1 · 2
I tend toward constipation with dry stools.	0 · 1 · 2
	Total: _____

Group D	Score
My body feels heavy and sluggish.	0 · 1 · 2
I carry extra weight, especially around the middle.	0 · 1 · 2
My face and forehead are oily.	0 · 1 · 2
My mouth often feels sticky, or I often clear phlegm from my throat.	0 · 1 · 2
	Total: _____

Yang-Deficient

阳虚质

You may notice: cold hands and feet, feeling the cold more than others, a preference for hot drinks, loose stools, waking at night to urinate, and lower energy in winter.

Yang is the body's warmth and fire. With too little of it, the whole system runs cool. The aim is to warm steadily, without overdoing the hottest foods.

Eat more: ginger, scallions, chives, leeks, chicken, lamb in winter, shrimp, walnuts, chestnuts, red dates, longan, cinnamon, black tea.

Eat less: watermelon, cucumber, bitter melon, crab, raw salads, iced drinks, green tea and cold desserts, especially in the morning.

A good habit: keep your belly, lower back and feet warm. On a sunny day, sit with the sun on your back for a few minutes. Older Chinese people call this *drinking the sunshine*.

Try: Ginger and Red Date Tea, Lamb and Ginger Soup, Chestnut and Chicken Soup.



Garlic chives, Allium tuberosum. Watercolor by Ishizaki Yūshi, c. 1820s.

Chapter Five

春
Spring

Rising, opening, beginning again



Red Japanese apricot, Prunus mume, whose blossoms open while snow is still on the ground. Watercolor by Ishizaki Yūshi, Nagasaki, c. 1820s. Naturalis Biodiversity Center.



Mung Bean Soup 绿豆汤

绿豆汤 *lǜ dòu tāng*

Mung Bean Soup

Serves 6 · 1 hour · 寒 Cold

The classic Chinese summer drink. In every Chinese home in July there is a pot of this on the stove or a jug of it in the refrigerator. It is cold in nature, clears heat and quenches thirst better than anything I know. Some families drink only the clear green liquid from the first half hour; others cook it until the beans burst into a thick, sweet soup. Both are right.

You will need

1 cup (200 g) dried mung beans
8 cups (2 liters) water
⅓ to ½ cup (65 to 100 g) rock sugar, to taste
2 slices ginger (optional, for sensitive stomachs)

1. Rinse the beans well. Soak them for 2 hours if you have time; it shortens the cooking.
2. Bring the water to a boil in a large pot, add the beans and ginger, and boil for 10 minutes. For the clear, green version, pour off some of the liquid now and keep it; this is the most cooling part.
3. Lower the heat, cover partly and simmer for 40 minutes to 1 hour, until the beans have split open and turned soft.
4. Add the rock sugar and stir until dissolved. Serve warm, at room temperature, or lightly chilled on a very hot day.

Mei's note. *Mung beans are cold in nature. If you tend to feel cold, have loose stools or are menstruating, drink a smaller bowl or add the ginger. Use a stainless steel or ceramic pot; the soup turns red in iron.*
